



Your Baby's 12-Month Developmental Milestones

1. Expressive Language (How Your Baby Communicates)

According to ASHA, expressive language at 12 months is about vocal exploration, sound combinations, and the exciting emergence of first words or word approximations.

Developmental Level	Word Count Expectation (12 Months)
Milestone (The Baseline)	Says 1 to 2 meaningful words (like "mama" or "dada") or word approximations (consistent sounds like "ba" for ball). This represents what ~90% of babies do.
Average (The Midline)	Typically uses 1 to 5 functional words or clear approximations consistently to communicate needs.
Above Average (The Headstart)	Communicates using a robust vocabulary of 6 to 10+ words or word approximations and signs, often attempting to imitate various new sounds.

- **First Words & Word Approximations:** Word approximations count such as saying "ba" for ball, "da" for down, or making consistent animal sounds (like "moo").
- **Exclamations & Signs:** Uses exclamatory expressions like "uh-oh!", "whoa!", or "beep-beep!". Baby sign language (e.g., signing "more" or "all done") also counts as expressive communication.
- **Jargon & Conversational Tone:** Uses long strings of babbling with adult-like intonation and inflection (jargon) that sounds like they are having a real conversation.
- **Gestures:** Waves "bye-bye," points to objects of interest to show them to you, and shakes their head "no."

2. Receptive Language (How Your Baby Understands)

Receptive skills reflect how your little one processes and reacts to the words and sounds around them.

- **Responding to Name:** Turns their head consistently or responds when their name is called.
- **Understanding Familiar Words:** Looks or points toward familiar objects, animals, or people when they are named (e.g., "Where's the ball?" or "Look at doggy").
- **Following Simple Directions:** Begins to follow basic, one-step commands, especially when accompanied by a visual gesture (e.g., "Give it to mommy" with an outstretched hand, or "Come here").
- **Pausing for "No":** Briefly stops what they are doing when caregivers say "no."

3. Play Skills (How Your Baby Learns and Interacts)

Play is a baby's primary way of learning about cause and effect, fine motor coordination, and social interaction.

- **Functional Play:** Begins to use objects correctly and functionally according to their purpose (e.g., trying to brush hair with a brush, putting a toy phone to their ear, or rolling a car).
- **Interactive Games:** Actively participates in simple interactive games like peek-a-boo, pat-a-cake, or clapping games.
- **Cause and Effect Exploration:** Deliberately drops or throws items (like toys or spoons) from a highchair to watch them fall and hear the sound they make.
- **Object Manipulation:** Puts objects into containers and takes them back out; stacks blocks or bangs two objects together.

4. Feeding Skills (How Your Baby Eats)

Feeding is a developmental journey. Around 12 months, your child is building essential sensory, motor, and oral skills for successful eating.

- **Refined Pincer Grasp:** Uses the tips of the thumb and index finger (pincer grasp) efficiently

to pick up small finger foods, bits of soft food, or crumbled snacks.

- **Spoon and Lip Clearing:** Clears food off a spoon cleanly using their upper lip rather than just scraping it against their teeth or gums.
- **Cup Drinking Transitions:** Begins to transition away from bottles and moves toward drinking water or milk from an open cup (with help) or a straw cup.
- **Biting & Textures:** Easily bites through soft textures (like pieces of soft fruit, cooked vegetables, or pancakes) using their front teeth and explores a wide variety of textures with their hands and mouth.
- **Self-Feeding Progress:** Attempts to hold and navigate a baby spoon, even if it is messy! Sensory play (like getting hands messy with purees or dipping food) is highly encouraged to support their sensory system.

When to Consult a Professional

Every child develops at their own pace, but it is always best to trust your instincts. Reach out to your pediatrician or a certified professional (such as a [Speech-Language Pathologist](#) or [Pediatric Feeding Therapist](#)) if your 12-month-old shows any of the following signs:

Area of Concern	Potential Red Flags
Speech & Language	Is not yet using 1-3 words or using consonants (like b, d, m, p); does not use gestures like waving or pointing; does not respond to their name or simple commands.
Play & Interaction	Does not make eye contact during interaction; shows no interest in simple interactive games like peek-a-boo; does not explore toys functionally.
Feeding	Demonstrates extreme distress, consistent tantrums, or refusal at mealtimes; coughs or chokes frequently during meals; completely avoids specific textures.

Jessica Aleman, MEd, CCC-SLP is a Pediatric Speech-Language Pathologist in Hoboken, NJ. She offers concierge speech and feeding therapy right in your home, at daycare, or virtually. *You can schedule a phone call to talk about your concerns on her website at www.JessicasSpeechandFeeding.com or you can email her at Jessica.njslp@gmail.com*